From here, the contradictions and inconsistences in India's statements and actions waned. Zhou responded to Nehru on 8 September 1959, saying that a settlement should take account of the historical background and 'existing actualities', i.e., the facts on the ground after all the incursions. He repeated China's view that no boundary delimitation existed in the west and the McMahon Line was a legacy of imperialist aggression. Nonetheless, Chinese troops would not challenge the McMahon Line. On 12 September, in Parliament, Nehru agreed that a formal, detailed delimitation of the border in the western sector did not exist but insisted that India's broad claim to Aksai Chin remained.[26] In his letter to Zhou on 26 September, he outlined India's strongest and clearest statement of its stand, rebutting all of Zhou's contentions in detail. In his defence of India's case, he invoked the historical record, as the Chinese premier had done, to arrive at exactly the opposite conclusion: the imperial agreements were valid because they had never been substantially challenged until then.[27]

Tipping points

With Nehru's August 1959 statement in Parliament on being ready to enter into discussions (although in September he rejected talks until the Chinese pulled back in various places along the boundary[28]), with Zhou's offer of a negotiated settlement in September 1959, and with both premiers agreeing that a delimitation of the western boundary was lacking, an accommodation should have been possible. Yet at least four occurrences caused the quarrel to tip over into almost irreversible disagreement.

The first tipping point was the briefing to Nehru in February 1960 by the Indian historian and adviser on the border, Sarvepalli Gopal. Based on his research, Gopal's conclusion was that India had a strong claim in Aksai Chin. If Nehru still harboured any doubts about India's western sector, they apparently evaporated after several hours with Gopal. India's stand now hardened.[29]